

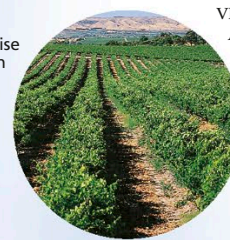


**UNIQUE WILDLIFE**  
Animal parks and refuges allow "townies" and tourists to get close to Australia's unique wildlife. They can see marsupials such as koalas and wallabies (left), as well as crocodiles, snakes, and the world's only egg-laying mammals—the platypus and the echidna.

*Voting in government elections in Australia is compulsory. Citizens who fail to vote can be fined.*



**TOURIST ATTRACTIONS**  
Tourism is important to Australia's economy, and there is plenty to attract visitors. Popular destinations include the tropical waters around the Great Barrier Reef (above), the modern cities of Sydney and Melbourne, and the impressive sight of Uluru (Ayers Rock), a mountainous rock sacred to the Aborigines.



**VINEYARDS**  
Australia boasts an impressive range of high-quality wine-growing regions, specializing in different grapes. Wines are exported to more than 90 countries.

**LIFE IN THE CITIES**  
Most Australians live in the coastal towns and cities of southeastern Australia, where the climate is cooler. Although Canberra is the capital, Sydney is the largest and oldest city, and is beautifully situated around Sydney Harbor. One of the world's most famous landmarks is the Sydney Opera House (below), which has five separate halls for concerts, operas, and plays. The design echoes the sails of a ship.

